

Intel 875PBZ

True to tradition

Intel boards are known for their stability, and with the added performance to boot, Intel has stuck another feather in its cap. The 875PBZ performed so well that we had to run the tests twice, just to believe the scores!

The board has its mix of goods and bad—the Northbridge is cooled by a big heat sink, sadly, without any fan or active cooling. The capacitor near the graphics card-locking mechanism is an irritant, especially when removing the card—it leaves hardly any space for accessing the lock. Now for the goods: the SATA ports, IDE connectors and the power connector are ideally placed. All the capacitors are half-sized near the CPU, and don't come in the way when installing the CPU—an extremely good feature.

Features are sparse on this board, as is reflected by the overall score—it is nearly 17 points behind the features winner. There are just two SATA ports, provided via the Southbridge. No extra ports are available courtesy third-party controllers. There's no onboard sound, Firewire capability or IDE RAID capability. Packaging is standard, and there are no frills. As with all Intel boards, overclocking isn't an option.

This board performed brilliantly, and was the only one that could challenge the MSI Neo. In *Quake III Arena*, in normal mode, the scores crossed the 500 fps barrier—only after we switched to a resolution of 1,280 x 1,024 did the score drop below 500 fps. Similarly, in all the other games, it raked high results, making it a good choice for gaming. In the real-world tests and the synthetic benchmarks, the performance was mixed, with the Intel and MSI swapping the laurels.

Priced at Rs 11,440, this is a great board—apart from the rock-solid stability, it also gives you superb performance. The only downside is the overclocking issue, and if you can overlook it, nothing beats this board in terms of price versus performance. This board can make a good, performing and stable gaming machine. Also, you can save the extra money to splurge on a sound card of your choice.

Price: Rs 11,440
+ Great performance, absolute value for money
- Lacks onboard sound

Intel 875PBZ	B+
Performance	■■■■■
Features	■■■■■
Build quality	■■■■■
Value for money	■■■■■

MSI 875P NEO

NEO, the one

The NEO series from MSI has always been exciting—for its packaged contents, plethora of features and of course, the BIOS tweaks for overclocking. And the MSI 875P does not disappoint.

The layout of components isn't as good as the Intel boards—the capacitors near the CPU make installation irritating; the ATX power supply connector also has capacitors that are likely to bend or break when removing the power connector; and the four memory slots are placed too close to each other, so using memory modules with heat sinks can be a problem. The SATA ports are perfectly placed, as is the IDE RAID connector. The AGP slot locks do not interfere with the memory locks—better than the Intel board.

The MSI 875P NEO comes with three colour-coded Firewire headers that can be used via the provided cable. The board does offer RAID capability, but you can attach only two SATA hard drives and one IDE drive—the Gigabyte board allows two each. The actively controlled Northbridge fan has differently coloured LEDs that flash in sequence. The sound system is RealTek's ALC 650 codec, which lacks high-fidelity output. The onboard promise SATA controller provides two more SATA ports, apart from those given by the Southbridge, and supports two modes—RAID 0 and RAID 1. The BIOS is quite intuitive, and the board can be overclocked easily. MSI has provided easy-to-use features in the BIOS, such as Frequency stepping, increasing the FSB and so on, that aid overclocking.

NEO's performance was unbeatable. In the gaming test, it beat the Intel by a slight margin—without overclocking. Only at higher resolutions in *Quake III Arena* did the Intel board beat the MSI convincingly. In the PC mark 04 and 3D Mark 03 tests, which are graphically demanding benchmarks, the MSI beat the Intel. The remaining tests results were even more dramatic, and the variation between them was negligible; the Neo nosed ahead in the end.

Priced at Rs 15,000, the MSI 875P NEO loses out on packaging to the Gigabyte, but edged out the Intel to take the Best Performance crown.

Price: Rs 15,000
+ Superb performance, good features
- Relatively bad layout design

MSI 875P NEO	B
Performance	■■■■■
Features	■■■■■
Build quality	■■■■■
Value for money	■■■■■